WAS THE HOLY SPIRIT ACTIVE IN OLD TESTAMENT TIMES? WHAT WAS NEW ABOUT THE CHRISTIAN EXPERIENCE OF GOD?

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Other papers in this symposium give expression to two common Christian convictions about the Holy Spirit. One is that that the Spirit was present and active in OT times only in a transient, non-universal, indirect, and ultimately unsatisfying way. The other, correlative conviction is that in fulfillment of OT hopes the Christian church is by definition the place where the Holy Spirit is fully present and active as a result of Christ's coming. I want to question both convictions.

TALK OF THE SPIRIT OF GOD IN OLD TESTAMENT TIMES

> On the last day of the festival...Jesus cried out, "Let anyone who is thirsty come to me, and let the one who believes in me drink. As the scripture has said, 'Out of the believer's heart shall flow rivers of living water.'"
> (John 7:37-38)

Those two sentences raise a number of questions. It may be more likely, for instance, that the one out of whose heart the rivers flow is Jesus, not the believer. But the issue which concerns us here arises from the comment which John goes on to make:

> Now he said this about the Spirit, which believers in him were to receive; for as yet there was no Spirit, because Jesus was not yet glorified.
> (John 7:39)

Thus the NRSV. It differs from the original RSV which has "the Spirit was not yet "given," the reading in some Greek manuscripts. The NRSV assumes that themanuscripts which say "given" are seeking to reduce the scandal of a difficult statement. "The Spirit was not" could sound as if it implied that the Spirit did not exist, which is the kind of misleading impression that a scribe might seek to remove. I think it likely that the NRSV is right and that John wrote "the Spirit was not," though this question, too, need make little difference to the issue I am concerned

with here.

For if John did write "the Spirit was not," he hardly means that the Spirit did not exist; he has already referred to the Spirit's activity in 1:32-33. Rather he means that the Spirit was not generally about, was not obviously there, was not active in relation to believers, or something of that kind. John will tell us later how Jesus breathes the Holy Spirit onto his disciples after his death and resurrection and how he commissions them for their ministry of bringing God's forgiveness (20:22-23). Scriptures such as Zechariah 14:8 which promise a flowing out of living waters will then be fulfilled. Until that happens, there is no Spirit, the Spirit is not obviously about or active, or the Spirit is not given, says John. The comment parallels the remark attributed to some disciples in Ephesus who knew only John's baptism and had not even heard that there was a Holy Spirit (Acts 19:2); its implication is that they did not know that Pentecost had taken place. They were still looking forward to the manifestation of the Holy Spirit.

The difficulty is that according to the other Gospels the Spirit of God has been very active before Jesus' ministry, and not just in relation to Jesus himself as in John 1:32-33. At the beginning of Luke, Elizabeth is "filled with the Holy Spirit," as is her husband Zechariah, and so will be their son John (Luke 1:15, 41, 67). The Holy Spirit was "on" the elderly Simeon, who had received a revelation from the Holy Spirit and came "in/by the Spirit" to the temple (Luke 2:25-27). In Jesus's own words according to Mark, David had long before that spoken "in the Holy Spirit" (Mark 12:36). All those passages mesh with the descriptions of the activity of Yhwh's spirit in the OT.

In considering the latter, we need to keep in mind a vital broadness and ambiguity in the OT and NT words for spirit. Both *ruach* and *pneuma* cover breath, wind, and spirit. Wind suggests something of the mysterious, invisible, dynamic power of God. Breath stands for life in its own mysterious nature, with its origins and its end outside our control. The wind is the breath of God, and we breathe because God breathes breath into us. The spirit of God or of a human being denotes their personal liveliness and dynamism, their motive power or will.

According to the OT, from the beginning this spirit of God has been involved in the process whereby God determined what to do in creating the world and in shaping events in the world. Isaiah of Babylon once asked "Who has directed the spirit of Yhwh?" in the fulfillment of these tasks (Isa 40:13). Genesis 1:2 with the *ruach* of God hovering over the waters, and Job 26:13 with God's *ruach* involved in creation alongside God's power, understanding, and hand, specifically associate the activity of God's *ruach* with God's activity from the beginning. Indeed, the very breath of humanity comes from that breath/wind/spirit of God. Psalm 104:29-30 assumes that human beings and animals breathe in because God's *ruach* breathes out (cf. Gen 6:3; Isa 42:5; Job 27:3; 33:4; 34:14; Qoh 12:7). Thus John Calvin remarks, "the beauty of the universe ... owes its strength and preservation to the power of the Spirit .... It is the Spirit who, everywhere diffused, sustains all things, causes them to grow, and quickens them in heaven and in earth."[2]

The OT thus begins by associating the activity of God's spirit with the world and not merely with the people of God. In the NT this activity is narrowed down. While NT talk of God's wisdom or word can relate to the whole cosmos,

God's Spirit is more confined to the Church. From an OT perspective, however, "to experience the fellowship of the Spirit inevitably carries Christianity beyond itself into the greater fellowship of all God's creatures. For *the commuity of creation*, in which all created things exist with one another, for one another and in one another, is also the *fellowship of the Holy Spirit*," so that experience of the latter leads us into concern for the former (J. Moltmann).[3]

For our understanding of Christian experience, I take it that a further implication of the link between God's Spirit and creation is that when God's Spirit comes to fill the Christian Church or the Christian believer and comes to produce the moral fruit of the Spirit or to release gifts of the Spirit, these are not some bolt-on additions to human nature as created by God. They are not essentially novel enlargements of this human nature, but the fulfillment of what created human beings are intended to be and have the inherent potential to be. In this sense the life of holiness or the utterance of tongues or the ministry of healing are the most natural things in the world, even if they become actual only through supernatural release and would never become fully actual without that. Thus the renewing of the Church is the shaping of a microcosm of creation. The breathing of John 20:22 is a repetition of the event of creation; it is an act of new creation. The groaning on the part of the Spirit in Romans 8:23-27 is a sighing for the fulfillment of creation. But it is because human beings in general are divinely created beings in-breathed with God's breath that they sometimes live holy lives, say things that are true and illuminating, and exercise gifts of healing.

Not surprisingly, the OT has further statements to make about the involvement of God's spirit with Israel in particular. When Israel was delivered at the Red Sea, this involved God's holy spirit being in their midst and giving them rest (Isa 63:11,14). When Israel was then directed through the wilderness, this was by God's good spirit (Neh 9:20). As Israelites lived their lives in the land over the centuries, God's spirit lived among them (Hag 2:4-5). When they ignored God's expectations and standards, they grieved that holy spirit among them (Isa 63:10) and risked its being withdrawn (Ps 51: 11 [13]), or they experienced God's *ruach* as a scorching blast from which they might like to escape but could not (Isa 4:4; 40:7; Ps 139:7). They thus prayed for God to renew and uphold them with the steadfast, holy, and generous spirit of God which can act on their spirit and make it more like God's (Ps 51:10-12 [12-14]).

The spirit of God also breathed into particular individuals within Israel. This happened to the craftworkers in the shrine, to leaders such as elders, to prophets, and to liberators such as the "judges." Things that they did suggested the life and energy of God; they reflected the active presence of God's *ruach*.

On the understanding of the OT itself, then, there is no doubt that the spirit of God was about and active in OT times, and the attitude which surfaces in the synoptic Gospels makes the same assumption. So what are we to make of John's comment? What was new about the giving of the Spirit through Jesus?

WHEN THE SPIRIT OF GOD IS ACTIVE BUT UNNAMED

Before coming to that question, with John's help I want to make it sharper. There is another significance about that comment in John 7:39. When Jesus talks

about rivers of living water, he does not explicitly allude to the Spirit of God. It is John who *assumes* that he refers to the Spirit, that the Spirit will bring about the fulfillment of Jesus's words. So why does Jesus not actually mention the Spirit? John implies that it is the fact that the Spirit "was not yet [given]" that explains this. In other words, the Spirit of God can be referred to even when the word *ruach* or *pneuma* does not appear.

John's comment thus provides us with an important clue for our theological interpretation of the OT. With hindsight, John implies, we can recognize reference to the Spirit even where the Spirit is unmentioned. Passages which refer to the work of the Holy Spirit include ones which use the word *ruach*, but also include others which do not.

The significance of the actual phrase "holy spirit" in the OT deserves comment. The phrase occurs in only two passages, in Isaiah 63 and Psalm 51. Yet in a sense this is a misleading observation, because arguably in OT thinking either the adjective or the noun is redundant in the expression. "Spirit" in itself defines the being of God, in dynamic power (cf. Isa 31:3). "Holy" in itself also defines the being of God, in supernatural awesomeness (cf. Hos 11:9b). It is therefore hardly surprising that the two words are so rarely combined; they risk tautology. Any reference to the spirit of God must be a reference to the holy spirit of God.

The possibility that the spirit of God may be present and active even when not explicitly mentioned surfaces within the OT itself. The OT talks of the activity of the spirit of Yhwh in connection with some prophets, such as Elijah, Elisha, and Ezekiel, but not in connection with others such as Jeremiah. Jeremiah's experience of the pressure of Yhwh upon him was in its way as tumultuous as that of Ezekiel, but he did not describe it in terms of Yhwh's spirit. He is usually reckoned to be avoiding such language because it is in some way discredited, perhaps through its use by other prophets from whom Jeremiah wished to distance himself. But if we accept that Ezekiel was acted on by Yhwh's spirit, it is natural to infer that this was also true of Jeremiah, even if Jeremiah avoids saying so and prefers to speak in terms of Yhwh's word. There is no systematic tension between God's word and God's spirit in the OT (see Ps 33:6).

Now in one sense it is dangerous to read back Christian theological ways of thinking into the OT. As David Steinmetz notes in his paper in this symposium, the incarnation itself points us to the significance of the literal sense of scripture. Indeed, I would want to add, the doctrine of creation and the assumptions in the OT about God's ongoing involvement in this world does that. We can easily miss the thrust of what the OT has to tell us by reading it through Christian spectacles too quickly. When translations render *ruach* by Spirit with a capital "S," they risk misleading us. In Psalm 51:11 [13] the NIV has "Holy Spirit" with capital "H" and capital "S," the RSV has "holy Spirit" with small "h" and capital "S," while the NRSV has small "h" and small "s." There are snags about the use of capitals which may make us read later meanings back into the passages and thus miss the passages' own meaning, miss what God's very Spirit had to say to people through the words as they would hear them in their day. But at some stage we may rightly consider statements in the OT in terms of Christian theological categories as part of seeking a theological understanding which will enable us to interpret God's activity in the world and the church today.[4]

In the OT, talk of the spirit of God is one of a number of ways of referring to the presence and activity of God. One can speak of God's arm, or hand, or finger, or face, or eyes, or wisdom, or name, or angel—or of God's breath/spirit. All of these are ways of speaking of God's presence and activity. They have two strengths. One is that the terms speak of these realities in a way which is more concrete than simple and unqualified reference to God. God's arm suggests God's power, God's hand suggests God's direct activity, God's face suggests God's personal concern, and so on. They also have the advantage of providing ways of speaking of God's presence and activity which preserve an awareness of God's own absoluteness and transcendence. We "only" experienced God's arm or hand; we do not pretend to have experienced all of God.

Reference to God's *ruach* is an instance of such speech. It suggests that God is truly present and active, with the power of wind and the liveliness of breath and the personal decisiveness of human decision-making, but it does so in a way which safeguards God's mystery. Wind and breath are invisible and are known only by their effects (cf. John 3:8).

In early Christianity the metaphor of God's breath/wind/spirit became so dominant among those OT anthropomorphic expressions that it largely subsumed all the others. People stopped talking so much about God's arm or God's face. The process can be seen within the NT in the parallel between the casting out of demons by God's finger (Luke 11:20) or by God's Spirit (Matt 12:28). Talk of God's Spirit became *the* way of envisaging the presence and activity of God in the world. Perhaps, a colleague suggests to me, a reason for the dominance of "Spirit" language henceforth was the emergence of the "body of Christ" language. Arms, fingers, and face now belong to that divine-human body, itself indwelt by divine breath.

An implication of this development is that wherever the OT refers to God's arm or hand or finger or face or eyes, in dogmatic terms it is speaking of the activity of the Holy Spirit. To use John's words, it did not speak in terms of the Spirit because the Spirit was not yet [given]. That talk would only become dominant after the events referred to in John 20 and Acts 2. The Holy Spirit was there and active in OT times, but the language for expressing this activity was more varied than was later the case. A parallel indication of this move appears in Jan du Rand's suggestion elsewhere in this symposium that the seven lamps/spirits in Revelation 4:5 are the seven lamps/eyes of Zechariah 4:2, 10, for which the reference to God's spirit in Zechariah 4:6 offers a form of exegetical basis (or at least an invitation to midrash).

Another example of the Spirit's being involved though unnamed in OT times emerges in the realm of worship. The NT assumes that the Spirit inspires our worship. It is because the Spirit is present and active among us that we sing God's praise and call upon God in prayer. It is as we are filled with the Spirit that we sing psalms and hymns and spiritual songs (Eph 5:19-20). So what is going on when OT Israel sings psalms? When the Church took over the Psalms and made the Psalter its own hymnbook, one implicit assumption was that these hymns and thanksgivings and prayers were ones inspired by the Spirit. That is the point made with regard to Psalm 110 in Mark 12:36. And presumably we are to apply to the Psalter the generalization in 2 Timothy 3:15-16 about the OT scriptures being *the-*

opneustos, God-breathed, inspired or ex-spired by God's Spirit, or (as I incline to think the word suggests) produced as a result of people being blown over by God. In NT terms, these praises and prayers are a fruit of the Spirit, even if they are not described as such in the OT (though see passages such as Ps 45: 1 [2]; 49:1-4 [2-5]). The Holy Spirit was evidently involved in OT worship.

In Israel people were not much inclined to speak of themselves as sons and daughters of God and of God as their Father, though they sometimes did so. (Isa 43:6 is noteworthy as the only passage in the entire Bible—except where it is quoted in 2 Cor 6:18—where God says "my daughters"). That may have been because it was too cheap and easy an idea. In the OT world, as in ours, people assumed that God was their father, and the OT perhaps distanced itself from that assumption, as it distanced itself from the idea that there would be an afterlife, which was accepted among some other middle eastern peoples. But the confidence, lack of inhibition, and enthusiasm of OT prayer and praise indicate that the people who prayed the Psalms enjoyed the same relationship with God as the one the NT describes in terms of being sons and daughters. People prayed in the Spirit to the Father, even if they did not put it that way.

The Holy Spirit was evidently also involved in the everyday lives of people who produced the fruit of the Spirit. The fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, generosity, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. When we read OT stories of Ruth or Hannah or Josiah or Nehemiah, we read stories of people whose lives often have some of those features. They are not described as people in whom the Spirit is active, but that is what they are. Further, this feature of OT experience rules out the attempt to articulate the difference between the OT and the NT experience of the Holy Spirit as an intermittent rather than a continuing matter, or as a corporate rather than an individual matter. The Spirit was evidently active on an ongoing basis in the lives of ordinary individuals in the OT as well as being involved on an occasional and a corporate basis.

All that fits with the assumption within the NT that the relationship between OT believers and God was essentially like that of NT believers rather than essentially unlike it. The argument of passages such as Romans 4 or Hebrews 11 depends on that assumption. It is, of course, the one which underlies much of the use of OT characters in Christian preaching.

These considerations add further force to the issue John raises for us. With so much activity of the Holy Spirit in OT times, how can John speak of the Spirit as not yet given?

WHEN THE SPIRIT OF GOD IS HOPED FOR

No doubt, one reason for John's speaking of the Spirit as not yet given is the way the OT itself speaks of a future endowment of God's spirit. It appears in Ezekiel 36-37 (and is anticipated in 11:17-20). There it is one of a number of images of God's future work in Israel. Some are presumably literal: the people will return to their land, will obey God's commands, and will prosper in the land. Others presuppose the metaphor of the people as having one body, one heart, and one spirit. The "heart" in OT thinking corresponds most closely to the mind in ours. Currently the people's heart or mind is like stone. This image suggests something

inert, inactive, and lifeless (Exod 15:16; Hab 2:19)—not directly "resistant" as we may assume, though that doubtless follows. God will replace their stone-dead mind with a mind that is more like flesh—vital and lively, or spirited (as we might say). A mind like flesh, a new spirit, and God's spirit are parallel expressions in Ezekiel 36:26-27.

In the NT it will become pejorative to describe someone's mind as fleshly, and in subsequent Christianity it will become customary to assume an antithesis between the spiritual and the bodily. In the OT to describe the mind as fleshly is a positive statement and the spirit is at home in the body. The image of people being made fleshly, lively, and spirited becomes an allegory in the following vision in Ezekiel 37, of the dry bones which are turned first into corpses and then into living people by the infusion of the divine spirit/wind/breath. All this will lead to the world coming to recognize that Yhwh is God; the worldwide perspective of Genesis 1-11 will be regained.

The image recurs in Isaiah 44:1-5 where "my spirit" is parallel with "my blessing" and these two are parallel with water and streams. It is the very imagery of John 7, though Isaiah 44 is not a passage to which the NT directly appeals. In Isaiah 44 the imagery suggests a renewal of the community at all levels—in its numbers, status, morale, faith, and social life. It recurs again in Joel 2:28-29 [3:1-2] in a promise for all people. There the fulfillment of this promise will issue in prophecies, dreams, and visions. The promise is followed seamlessly by reference to the great and terrible day of Yhwh. And it is this passage which provides Acts 2 with the clue to understanding what is going on at the first Pentecost after Jesus' resurrection.

What do prophecies such as these imply regarding God's activity in OT times? Do they indicate the assumption that God's Spirit was not active, was not obviously there?

The perspective suggested by a number of passages is that in these prophets' own day God's spirit was not obviously active, but that people knew of such an activity in the past. The possibility of God's spirit being withdrawn is presupposed by Psalm 51:10-12 [12-14], a psalm which brings several issues into focus. Its heading suggests a connection with David and in modern parlance invite us to take this as a royal psalm. That would make good sense of the reference to Yhwh's holy spirit, for the king is one with whom Yhwh's spirit is especially associated. It is evident that hopes of the king being filled with Yhwh's spirit were often disappointed, and these hopes are the content of the promises in passages such as Isaiah 11:15. But aspects of the content of Psalm 51 make it unlikely that its heading is designed to tell us its actual origin. From the David who had had an affair with Bathsheba and arranged for her husband's death, Yhwh could hardly have accepted a prayer in which David professed to have sinned against Yhwh alone (v. 4), and the closing verses seem to presuppose a setting after the fall of Jerusalem. B. S. Childs thus plausibly suggests that headings such as that to Psalm 51 are lectionary notes which are not designed to determine authorship, but to suggest contexts against which to read the psalm in question.[5]

However this may be, it is noteworthy that these headings link their psalms with essentially "private" events in David's life of the kind that can have equivalents in the lives of ordinary people. They thus imply (in this case) that or-

dinary people might see themselves as knowing the presence of Yhwh's holy spirit. This was not confined to people such as judges, kings, and prophets and their fulfillment of roles in relation to the community. If we leave the heading on one side for a moment, on the other hand, it makes good sense to see the psalm as a communal one, spoken by the community after the fall of Jerusalem. Its "I" then either indicates its awareness of itself as a corporate entity, or it constitutes the "I" of each individual within the community which prays it (cf. the "I" of the prayers in Lamentations). It is then the community which asks that God's holy spirit be not withdrawn from it. Whoever prays this prayer mentions the spirit three times in vv. 10-12 [12-14]. Each time the word begins the second half of the line and is followed by a qualifying adjective. It seems natural to take "spirit" to refer to the spirit of God each time, or to the spirit of God at work on the human spirit.[6] The only point at which the Psalm refers unequivocally to the human spirit is the later allusion to a broken spirit (v. 17 [19]). In vv. 10-12 [12-14] the psalm prays that God's upright, holy, generous spirit may be given, may not be withdrawn, and may sustain. The failures of the past make it entirely possible to envisage Yhwh's withholding that spirit; but if Yhwh does, that is the end.

The experience of God's spirit being known in the past but not now is explicit in Isaiah 63, which speaks of the presence and activity of Yhwh's holy spirit within the people at the time of the exodus, the escape from the Red Sea, and the entering into the land. That was once a reality, but the people now see no evidence of such activity. A similar perspective is implicit in Isaiah 44. The kind of refreshment, blessing, flourishing, and recognition of Yhwh which vv. 1-5 express and which can also be envisaged by the figure of Yhwh's *ruach* being poured on people has been known in the past, but seems to be missing in the community's present experience of Yhwh's punishment.

Something more equivocal has to be said about Ezekiel. The community which is now lifeless and hopeless will be brought back to life by the in-breathing of Yhwh's *ruach*. That suggests the assumption that before their death that ruach was present; what is needed is its return. On the other hand, Ezekiel has a radically negative view of the people's previous life, and the promise in 36:26-27 implies a radically negative assessment of the people's spirit. Only if Yhwh's spirit is put within them will they come to live Yhwh's way. By implication, their failure over many centuries reflects the fact that this spirit has not been put into them before. Something creatively new is needed, and the breathing in of Yhwh's spirit is that new thing.

In Joel, the implication seems to be that the pouring out of Yhwh's spirit is a repetition of something which has been known in the past, but is not known now, and yet that this pouring out will surpass what has been known before. It will envelop not merely isolated individuals but people of all ages and classes and both sexes. Joel thus implies the conviction that God intends to do something in the future which will be even more splendid than what God has done in the past. He thus most clearly implies a typological way of thinking in which future events will parallel past events but exceed them in wonder. It is thus nice that Peter's allusion to him in Acts 2 takes the fulfillment of his words as itself exceeding the prophecy.

WHEN ARE THESE HOPES FULFILLED?

In some sense these prophetic promises were fulfilled in the Second Temple period. The community was renewed; the presence of Yhwh returned. At the same time, passages such as Isaiah 63 themselves witness to the recognition that many hopes were unfulfilled. John then implies the conviction that the new thing which God promised has now come about in true fullness in Jesus Christ. It is part of God's ultimate act having taken place in him. The End has come in Jesus. The last days have arrived. The Spirit is now about and active because Jesus has been about and active; the Spirit (we now realize) is the Spirit of Jesus.

Yet that is not the whole truth. In another sense the End has still not come, any more than it had in Second Temple Judaism. The last days have still not arrived. Everything continues as it did before, to echo the complaint reported in 2 Peter 3:4.

This is not merely a chronological point. We must consider the question in what sense God really has now fulfilled the promises in Ezekiel 36-37. Ezekiel envisages the people given a lively, spirited, flexible mind such as will enable them to walk in God's ways and share God's perspective and concern for the world. The Jewish-Gentile Church reckons to be the heir to that promise. (We will leave on one side here the question of the status of the ongoing Jewish people itself). It is not obvious that this Church any more possesses a consistently lively, spirited, flexible, responsive, God-aware, world-aware mind than OT Israel did. In this sense the promise has not been fulfilled.

A consideration of the parallel prophecy in Jeremiah 31:31-34 may help to sharpen the point, though in keeping with the apparent avoidance of "spirit" language in Jeremiah it does not explicitly mention God's spirit. It promises that Yhwh's teaching will be written in the minds of the people rather as regulations are written in a registrar's mind. As a result they will not need to teach or exhort each other to acknowledge Yhwh because they will all individually do so instinctively. The NT at one point says that this promise has been kept (Heb 8:8-12; 10:14-17), and elsewhere in this symposium Scott Hafemann argues that 1 Corinthians also implies it. Yet the NT may seem to deny it by the extent to which it offers teaching and exhortation, and in due course encourages the development of an institutional ministry which corresponds to that of OT Israel whose end Jeremiah heralds. Further, Romans 11:27 seems to locate the realization of Jer 31:31-34 in the future.

Joel similarly promised that the spirit of Yhwh would make it natural for people of all ages and classes and of both sexes to prophesy, in keeping with Moses's longing (Num 11:29). Acts declares that Joel's promise has been fulfilled. But in the history of the Church the gift of prophecy has been hardly more prevalent than was the case within OT Israel, and the priesthood of OT Israel has been reestablished in the Church. Further, whereas Acts implies that the fulfillment of Joel's vision of God's spirit poured out on "all flesh" goes beyond Joel's expectations (which hardly embraced "all peoples"), on the whole over the centuries the Church has largely resembled Israel in confining its horizon to its own life rather than working out the implications of God being creator and lover of the whole world.

Paul pictures the Holy Spirit as dwelling in the Christian community as if the community were a temple, and speaks of this as a fulfillment of OT hopes which built on the recognition that the God who dwelt and travelled with the people of Abraham and Moses cannot be contained in stone buildings (2 Cor 6:16). The Christian Church then rebuilt the OT temple in its buildings, some of which have its common tri-partite structure, and transferred the word "church" to these buildings.

In practice the position and lives of Christian believers are not so very different from those of OT believers. We are like Ruth and Hannah who produce the fruit of the Spirit, but also like Jacob and David who more obviously live more according to the flesh.

Having asserted that God's definitive revelation has come in Christ, Wolfhart Pannenberg remarks:

> But is this really so? Even two thousand years after the birth of Christ does not humanity offer the picture of an unreconciled world? Have Christians made much change? Has not the church itself been drawn into worldly conflicts? Has it not even multiplied and sharpened these conflicts by its impatience and divisions?[7]

Even two thousand years after the giving of the Spirit, we may add. It is as if the Spirit is not yet [given]. Or rather, if we look at it from the perspective of 1 Corinthians, it is not as if the Spirit is not yet [given]—far from it, in fact—but as if the giving of the Spirit has brought as many problems as it solved. So the Corinthian church is as liable to covenant lawsuit and divine casting-off as was OT Israel.[8] As Calvin put it (see David Steinmetz's paper), there is only one covenant, that with Israel into which the Church is admitted. Israel and the Church are in analogous situations, and letter and spirit run through both OT and NT faith rather than distinguishing one from the other.

Like Paul, Calvin is thus quite realistic about the nature of the Church and the consequences of the giving of the Spirit. In contrast, much theological talk of the Church and the Spirit seems theology floating in the air, out of touch with the reality of the Church as we know it, theological theory untroubled by empirical fact. My friends sometimes chide me for preferring movies such as *Once Upon A Time in America*, *Paris Texas*, and *Leaving Las Vegas* to *Sense and Sensibility* and *Emma*, not to say *101 Dalmatians*. I prefer the former because they work with the anguish, the grief, the loss, and the guilt of real life, and in the context of that realism work out what love, comfort, hope, and forgiveness might mean. The latter have everyone in the end marrying the right people and living happily ever after in a way which denies how life is. I have the same problem with theologies which seem to construct worlds of their own in the air and fail to touch base with life as it is.

THE WITNESS OF THE SPIRIT

So what did Jesus actually achieve? What difference did his coming make? Classically there is an objective, datable aspect to this question, and a subjective, experiential aspect. On the first side, Christian faith claims that Jesus was

the first human being to live his whole life by the Spirit in obedience to the Father; it was this that enabled him by his final act of obedience to make atonement for the rest of humanity. Henceforth, the gospel claims, the whole world is to be invited to live with God on the basis of this act of self-offering. Given that OT Israel had been invited to live with God before this event, on what basis did it do so? It was surely on the same basis, even though the event had not yet taken place. Jesus's act of obedience by anticipation applied to those OT believers too. They lived with God on the same basis as we do. They too prayed in the Spirit to the Father through Christ, though they used none of these prepositional phrases.

Or put Jesus' achievement in terms of his winning a unique victory over powers of evil, whose fruits those who belong to him can also enjoy. Did OT Israel exercise victory over powers of evil? That was envisaged in Genesis 1 and was experienced in Egypt and at the Red Sea, while in the Psalms, Israelites put evil to flight and enjoyed the freedom to bless and to curse. Again the effectiveness of Jesus' act evidently applied to OT believers.

Or put Jesus' achievement in terms of the opening of the door to eternal life. Were OT believers to stay dead when they died? Here more explicitly NT writers imply the conviction that Christ opens this door for believers who lived before him as well as for his contemporaries and for people who would live afterwards (e. g. Matt 27:51-53; 1 Pet 4:6).

Or put Jesus' significance in terms which have been especially appealing this century. Jesus took experience of human life, suffering, and death into the Godhead. Here something novel happened, though again it is something in continuity with the OT, for the possibility of God's becoming human was grounded in humanity's having been made in God's image, and the OT hints at the pain in the heart of God at the awareness of human pain. It was not least in the context of their distress that Israel knew the manifestation of Yhwh's personal presence in the form of the dynamic presence of Yhwh's holy spirit (Isa 63:8-14). Even the capacity to die was a capacity in God from the beginning.

In the datable once-for-all Christ-event with a before and after, Jesus did in due course make his offering, win his victory, open a door, and take the experience of death into the Godhead. As H. F. Woodhouse points out, all that gave the Spirit something to witness to (John14:26;16:14).[9] The nature of witness is that its object is something which has actually happened. It was indispensible that Christ should die in once-for-all history, for the fruits of this event are the fruits of this event, but objectively or theologically it might make no difference to believers whether they lived before or after it, because Christ's achievement applies to believers before him as well as after him. Subjectively, however, it would make a significant difference, because to people who live after Christ the Spirit can give explicit witness to what Christ has now actually done, as something that can be directly reflected on and appreciated.

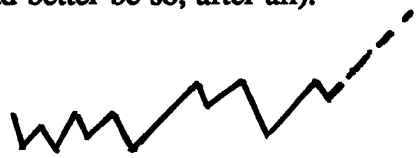
So after the actual death of Christ, people can understand directly how it affects them; and to judge from a passage such as Romans 6, understanding this will make a difference to their experience of its fruits. After the actual death of Christ, people can know that the great victory over evil has been won. This will naturally add to their expectations of what God can achieve through them. After the actual death of Christ, people can know that they will enjoy eternal life, rather

than being ignorant of this fact. They can know the Spirit as the Spirit of eternal life, not just of this life. That, too, will make a difference to their present experience as they now live their life in new hope. After the actual death of Christ, people have new concrete evidence of the length, depth, height, and breadth of the love of God, and the Spirit has more basis on which to overwhelm them with the love of God (Rom 5:5). OT faith operated according to the same logic: the facts of the Exodus and the covenant became ones which were brought home in theological argument to the community, generation by generation, as facts which could and should revolutionize their own experience and lives. Conversely their own experience of Yhwh as liberating God creatively affected their telling of the Exodus-covenant story. NT faith now has this new event explicitly to bring home.

In each case the difference in the nature of the Christian experience of God comes not simply because of what Christ has done; OT believers also enjoyed the benefits of that. It was indispensible that Christ should do what he did, but its fuller fruit in people's experience comes from their being able to know about this event, to receive the Spirit's witness to it, which can be given because the event is now something actual. It is this which makes for a difference between Abraham's experience of God and Paul's. And it is for this reason that God's expectations of the people of Jesus can be higher than God's expectations of OT Israel. In this sense, whereas they lived by faith, we live by sight. The Spirit can explicitly work to the expression in us of a cross-shaped life.

That also makes it the more pathetic that the people of Jesus are as much like Jacob and David as like Ruth and Hannah, and that the Christian community may seem to experience less victory over evil than Israel did, and less freedom in prayer and praise than the OT envisages.

Taking John 7 in isolation could lead to Christians operating with a once-for-all-step upwards model of the relationship between the activity of the Holy Spirit in OT and NT times. More appropriate is an up-and-down model which presupposes gains and losses within OT times and recognizes that the Holy Spirit has by no means yet finished with us (which had better be so, after all).

Not but 

Instead of an up-and-down zigzag one might compare the Holy Spirit with a volcano. This volcano erupted at creation, at the Exodus, at the building of the Second Temple, most spectacularly and irrevocably at the Christ event, at the Reformation, at Azusa Street, and on other occasions. Like many volcanoes it has been continuously but less spectacularly oozing lava and rumbling, so that every generation knows something of its inner nature and effect and is ever reminded of its potential power.

The NT comprises reflection on that most spectacular of eruptions. Systematic theology comprises reflection on that reflection, two steps away from the reality, written in the pretence that the oozing we have seen means we have experienced an eruption ourselves, and thus risking failure to look for an eruption

which is not scaled down to our current experience. We would be better off assailing God with the plea, "If this is your volcano, can't you let it blow off again in the way you have in the past, even in OT times?" This would be more hopeful than telling ourselves how fortunate we are that the Spirit has been given and that we now have everything there is to have. As the prophets encourage, we could be living in hope like them, rather than speaking as if all hopes have been fulfilled and thereby implying that we are therefore hopeless.

CONCLUSION

On the one hand, I have wanted to argue, the nature of OT believers' relationship with God in the Holy Spirit needs to be taken more seriously; they model for us a life lived in the Spirit. On the other, all the potential of God's ultimate act in Jesus and in the Spirit lies before us in a more explicit way than was the case for them.

A crucial key to entering into it is knowledge of it, because that is the one thing we have that the OT saints did not have. One might even say that this key is the study of theology.

Perhaps it is to be expected that a theologian would say this. Living gnostically myself, I protect my salary by seeking that others live gnostically. Surely Pentecost was more than knowledge? Indeed it was, but it was not less than that, and without knowledge the Pentecost experience would not have been shared by the other people in Jerusalem that day. The link between the Spirit falling on some and not on others was the "some" giving the "others" that information about Jesus and themselves which was power.

Coming to listen more carefully to the Spirit's witness is thus a vital potential key to discovering the riches that we have in Christ Jesus in the Spirit, riches which far exceed anything which we have begun to enjoy. Like OT Israel, we are invited to live not on the hopeless assumption that we already have all that we are going to have, but to live in hope, to live in the conviction that what God intends for us far exceeds what we now experience. It is the Holy Spirit who encourages that hope, who is the guarantee that it is not empty hope, who works in us whatever fulfillment of it we now experience, who has the capacity to work in us that fulfillment which goes far beyond what we have begun to enjoy, and who invites us actively to seek that fulfillment.

How do we do that? During one of the sessions in the Ex Auditu consultation I found myself listening to Evangelicals and Pentecostals discussing the shortcomings of the charismatic movement, with which I identify.[10] The point was made that the charismatic movement has an inherent inclination to triumphalism which is lacking in Pentecostalism. The latter has always recognized that not everyone gets healed. It has sat in anguish with people in their "unhealedness," as well as rejoiced in God's mighty works for people.

A propos of that great flawed OT figure whose painful truth is told in 2 Samuel 9-1 Kings 2, Walter Brueggemann remarks on the

> ... biblical discernment that human personhood, bound as it must be to public history, is always and inevitably a life of anguish. On the one hand,

> such an insight is a refutation of all modern romanticism that believes and promises that life can be uncomplicated like "I'm O. K., you're O. K." On the other hand, it is a remarkable ancient discernment which argues against all mythic notions that human life does not count for anything and that the gods manage it all. This narrative asserts against both ancient and modern deceptions that human life has freedom and anguish, power and pain, and neither is avoidable for those mirrored in this astonishing man.[11]

And this is the man whom Psalm 51 pictures praying that the holy spirit would not be taken away from him, a psalm whose heading indeed invites us to see ourselves mirrored in him.

If the Holy Spirit is the Spirit of the cross, then it will not be surprising if a new openness to the Spirit will involve an openness to anguish, and therefore an integrity which declines to hide from ambiguity, pain, or failure.[12] Rather it starts from these in seeking to discover something of the volcanic power of the Spirit of God. It is surely no coincidence that the Church of the developing world is often both a Church which lives with more anguish than does the Church in the developed world and a Church which knows more of the reality of the Holy Spirit. Church and individual believers in the developing world have their anguish; the question is whether they will own it. Likewise it is striking that the "mainstream" Church is more open than it once was to learning from Pentecostalism whose experience has been that of being by background unfashionable, despised, and marginalized in relation to the Church that "really" counts. Both these mesh with the conviction presupposed in Galatians (according to C. H. Cosgrove) that "participation in the crucifixion of Christ is the sole condition for ongoing life in the Spirit."[13] I am not sure that we can say that such preparedness and openness is bound to unleash the Spirit. One can say that it is the least we can manifest if we desire that unleashing.

NOTES

1. In this form the paper has profited materially from discussions with students and staff at North Park Theological Seminary, Chicago, Illinois, at Columbia Seminary, Decatur, Georgia, at the Church of God School of Theology, Cleveland, Tennessee, and of course, at St. John's College, Nottingham.

2. *Institutes of the Christian Religion* (London: SCM, 1960), I.13.14. See further R. K. Johnston's paper in this volume.

3. *The Spirit of Life* (London: SCM, 1992), 10, his emphasis; see also *God in Creation* (London: SCM, 1985), 9-13, 98-103, 255-270.

4. In this paper I have followed the NRSV in using "[holy] spirit" for references to OT texts but "[Holy] Spirit" for references to NT texts as well as for reference to the Holy Spirit as the third person of the Trinity, though I grant that the use of [Holy] Spirit for NT texts also risks reading post-biblical Christian categories into them.

5. See "Psalm Titles and Midrashic Exegesis," *Journal of Semitic Studies* 16 (1971) 137-150; *Introduction to the Old Testament as Scripture* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1979), 520-522.

6. See M. E. Tate, *Psalms 51-100* (Dallas: Word, 1990), 22-25.

7. *Systemaic Theology*, Vol. I (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1991), 441.

8. See Scott Hafemann's paper in this symposium with his exegesis of Jer 31:31-34, though I cannot follow his argument that in Paul's thinking the Church is nevertheless in reality a community in which that promise is indeed fulfilled.

9. See "The Holy Ghost was not yet Given," *Theology* 67 (1964) 310-312.
10. See e. g., "Charismatic Spirituality," *Theology* 99 (1996) 178-187.
11. *David's Truth in Israel's Imagination and Memory* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1985), 45.
12. On this integrity, see T. H. Troeger, "Emerging New Standards in the Evaluation of Effective Preaching," *Worship* 64 (1990) 294-307.
13. *The Cross and the Spirit* (Macon GA: Mercer, 1988), 172.

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